

- RAG Learning

3.7 Anarchism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Anarchism holds that the state is **unnecessary and harmful**, and that society should be organised without compulsory authority. It is the only ideology to reject the state outright — and it contains two traditions, derived from socialism and from liberalism respectively, which agree on almost nothing except that.

Optional ideology. Students study *one* of nationalism, feminism, multiculturalism, anarchism or ecologism.

AQA key thinkers for anarchism: Max Stirner, Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, Mikhail Bakunin, Peter Kropotkin and Emma Goldman.

1. Core ideas

Anti-statism

Four objections, and you should be able to distinguish them:

- **Coercive** — the state rests ultimately on force, compelling obedience regardless of individual consent.
- **Sovereign** — it claims supreme authority over everyone in its territory, which anarchists deny can be legitimate.
- **Corrupting** — power corrupts those who exercise it, so even well-intentioned rulers become oppressive. This is why anarchists reject *capturing* the state as a route to liberation.
- **Unnecessary** — human beings are capable of voluntary cooperation, so order does not require compulsory authority.

Liberty

Absolute personal autonomy is the supreme value. Anarchists reject not only the state but every form of imposed authority — which is what distinguishes them from liberals, who accept a limited state as necessary.

Anti-clericalism

Organised religion, like the state, demands obedience to an external authority and teaches submission, so it reinforces hierarchy. Bakunin in particular treated church and state as twin pillars of domination.

Economic freedom

All anarchists reject arrangements producing domination — but they divide sharply on what that means for property, which is the fault line between the two traditions.

Utopianism

An optimistic view of human nature: a harmonious society is achievable without coercive authority. Anarchists generally hold that the selfishness and violence attributed to human nature are *produced by hierarchical institutions* rather than inherent in people.

2. The two traditions

	Collectivist anarchism	Individualist anarchism
Derived from	Socialism	Liberalism
Human nature	Sociable, cooperative, communal	The sovereign, self-creating individual
Property	Common ownership, or possession by those who work it	Private property and voluntary exchange

Organisation	Communes, cooperatives, revolutionary trade unions, federations	Voluntary contract between individuals
Thinkers	Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin, Goldman	Stirner; later anarcho-capitalism

Exam Tip: This is the key to almost every 25-mark question on anarchism. The two traditions **share only opposition to the state**; on property, economics and human nature they are close to opposites. It exposes a fundamental ambiguity: does anarchism oppose *the state specifically*, or *hierarchy and domination in general*? The two traditions answer differently.

3. Key thinkers

Max Stirner (1806–1856) — *The Ego and Its Own* (1844)

- **Egoism** — the individual should recognise no authority above their own will.
- **"Spooks"** — the state, religion, morality, the nation and even "humanity" are abstractions that constrain the self and should be rejected.
- **Beyond political anti-authoritarianism** — he rejects moral duty itself, which makes his position the most radical in the tradition.
- **The union of egoists** — a voluntary association entered into purely for mutual advantage, dissolvable at will.

Pierre-Joseph Proudhon (1809–1865) — *What Is Property?* (1840)

- **"Property is theft"** — where it permits an owner to live off others' labour. But he *defended possession* by those who work the land or tools, so he is not opposed to all private holding.
- **Mutualism** — an economy of independent producers and small cooperatives exchanging goods at fair value.
- **People's banks** — credit supplied at cost rather than by capitalist finance.

- **Federalism** — society organised through voluntary federations from the bottom up. The first person to call himself an anarchist.

Mikhail Bakunin (1814–1876)

- **Collectivist anarchism** — common ownership of the means of production, with distribution according to work done.
- **Against Marx's transitional state** — the decisive dispute in the First International. Bakunin argued that *any* state, including a workers' state, would develop its own interests and become a new apparatus of domination. It would not wither away.
- **"Propaganda of the deed"** — revolutionary action, including violence, as a means of inspiring mass uprising.
- **Broader revolutionary base** — the peasantry and the dispossessed as well as the industrial proletariat.
- **Means shape ends** — a hierarchical movement cannot produce a free society.

Exam Tip: Bakunin's prediction that a workers' state would entrench a new ruling stratum rather than wither away was **substantially vindicated** by the history of twentieth-century communist states. It is the strongest historical support any anarchist argument has received, and it should appear in any question on anarchism versus Marxism.

Peter Kropotkin (1842–1921) — *Mutual Aid* (1902)

- **Mutual aid** — voluntary reciprocal cooperation is widespread among animals and humans and is a major factor in evolutionary success, *not* merely competition between individuals.
- **Scientific foundation** — this is offered as empirical evidence, answering the central objection to anarchism: if cooperation is natural, social order does not require a coercive state to create it.
- **Anarcho-communism** — common ownership with distribution *according to need*, rejecting exchange and wages altogether. This goes further than Proudhon's mutualism.
- **Federations of self-governing communes** as the organising structure.

Emma Goldman (1869–1940)

- **Anarchism extended to personal life** — marriage, conventional sexual morality and the expectations placed on women are forms of authority constraining the individual.
- **Critique of suffrage-focused feminism** — the vote alone cannot emancipate women, because formal political rights leave intact the economic dependence and internalised constraint that actually restrict freedom. Emancipation must be internal as well as legal.
- **Free union** — relationships based on mutual affection rather than legal or religious sanction.
- **Free expression and the arts** as means of individual flourishing.
- **Critique of the Bolsheviks** — having initially supported the Russian Revolution, she condemned it after witnessing its suppression of dissent, giving anarchist warnings first-hand force.

4. Strands and methods

Strand	Economic form	Route to change
Mutualism	Independent producers exchanging at fair value; people's banks	Gradual building of alternative institutions
Anarcho-collectivism	Common ownership; distribution by work done	Revolution; propaganda of the deed
Anarcho-communism	Common ownership; distribution by need	Revolution; federated communes
Anarcho-syndicalism	Industry run by the workers	Revolutionary trade unions and the general strike ; the unions become the structure of the new society
Egoism	Whatever the individual can secure	Individual rejection of all "spooks"
Anarcho-capitalism	Unrestricted markets; private property; protection and law from competing private agencies	Withdrawal from and replacement of the state

Why anarchists reject elections

Participation *legitimises* the state's authority, and power corrupts those who acquire it — so the state cannot be used to abolish itself. This distinguishes anarchism sharply from social democracy.

5. Tensions between the thinkers

Disagreement	One side	The other
Property	Kropotkin — common ownership, distribution by need	Stirner — whatever the individual can take and hold
Human nature	Kropotkin — naturally cooperative; mutual aid	Stirner — the self-interested, self-creating ego owing nothing to others
Exchange	Proudhon — fair exchange between independent producers	Kropotkin — abolish exchange and wages altogether
Method	Bakunin — revolution, including propaganda of the deed	Proudhon — gradual building of alternative institutions
Scope of authority rejected	Goldman — including marriage, sexual morality, gender norms	Earlier anarchists — focused on state, church and capital

6. Is anarchism utopian?

The charge	The reply
Human nature — without enforceable rules, disputes would be settled by the strongest; abolishing the state replaces public authority with private domination	Kropotkin's mutual aid shows cooperation is widespread in nature and human society; observed selfishness is produced by the very institutions anarchists would abolish

No mechanism — vague about dispute resolution, large-scale infrastructure, and dealing with those who refuse to cooperate	Federal and consensual structures can perform these functions; demanding a blueprint imports statist assumptions
The record — no anarchist society sustained at scale; revolutionary Catalonia and Ukraine were destroyed	They were defeated by <i>states</i> , not by internal collapse — which partly proves the anarchist point

Exam Tip: The most sophisticated version of the utopian charge is **structural, not moral:** anarchism's rejection of hierarchy and of capturing state power deprives it of the instruments by which movements consolidate change. It is therefore systematically disadvantaged against opponents who use both. That is not a refutation of anarchist principles — but it does describe a movement whose means are constrained by its ends.

7. Is anarcho-capitalism anarchist?

Yes: it opposes the state, which is the defining anarchist commitment, and is internally consistent.

No: classical anarchists argue that concentrated *private* economic power is itself a form of domination, and that private protection agencies holding a monopoly of force in a territory would resemble states in all but name. It abolishes public authority while preserving the hierarchy anarchism exists to oppose.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Anti-statism	Rejection of the state as coercive, sovereign, corrupting and unnecessary
Egoism	Recognising no authority above one's own will (Stirner)
Mutualism	Fair exchange between independent producers, with credit at cost (Proudhon)

Mutual aid	Voluntary reciprocal cooperation as a factor in evolution (Kropotkin)
Anarcho-syndicalism	Revolutionary trade unions and the general strike as the route to, and structure of, a stateless society
Propaganda of the deed	Revolutionary action intended to inspire mass uprising (Bakunin)
Spontaneous order	Social order emerging from voluntary cooperation without coercion
Collectivisation	Transfer of property to common ownership
Anti-clericalism	Opposition to organised religion as a source of hierarchy and submission
Utopianism	Belief in the achievability of a harmonious society without coercive authority
Free union	Relationships based on mutual affection rather than legal sanction (Goldman)